Maintaining Security at the Shelter

Guidance for workers in shelters on establishing and maintaining a secure and safe operating location

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Sheltering Manager, AD Logistics, DRO Safety Officer

Considerations

- In most cases, shelter workers are relied on to maintain a safe environment for all.
- If the client population grows and complexity of the sheltering operation, then law enforcement or private security officers may be needed.
    - While it's essential to keep the shelter, clients and workforce safe, the presence of law enforcement may create uneasiness among some people or deter certain clients from seeking Red Cross assistance.
    - Private security must understand that the shelter is a temporary home for clients, and their safety must be ensured without compromising their dignity and privacy.
    - Private security is not authorized to remove clients from the shelter without coordination and approval

from the Shelter Site Manager (see **Evicting a Client from the Shelter** task sheet).

- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Household Pets and Service Animals
  - Non-Traditional Sheltering
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Arranging and working with outside security

- Identify when additional security is needed/
  - Discuss security concerns with the HQ Sheltering Manager and work with other leaders to arrange security personnel.
  - Arrange for a temporary solution(such as local law enforcement) while procuring a private security service.

- Guide law enforcement or private security at the shelter.
  - Coordinate resources they may need with the supervisor of the security agency, such as meals, workspace, pop-up canopy, etc.
  - Inform them of all areas of the shelter where patrols are necessary and ask for their advice on other areas.
    - Generally, security officers are not e permanently positioned at the entrance of the shelter or in the reception area.

  - Aim for a balance between maintaining security and creating a welcoming and comfortable environment.

Maintaining security with Red Cross Staff

When Red Cross staff maintains security, they receive direction from the Shelter Site Manager and are responsible for the following:

- Restrict entry to authorized people.
    - Close the facility perimeter to visitors and control the entry of new clients.
    - Only allow entry to authorized people.
    - Only pet owners, authorized Red Cross workforce and animal welfare partners may be admitted into the pet area.

- Monitor the inside and outside areas.
    - The Shelter Site Manager advises all the areas (including pet services area) and schedule for patrols,.
    - Two workers are assigned to patrol the perimeter together.
    - Check that all outside doors are closed and locked from the outside but can be opened from the inside in case of an emergency.
    - Report any illegal activity to law enforcement.

- Watch for suspicious activity
    - Notify the Shelter Site Manager if you notice suspicious activity inside or outside of the shelter.
    - Call 911 for urgent situations when the Shelter Site Manager is unavailable.
    - Do not investigate suspicious activity on your own.

Related Information

Maintaining Safety and Health in Shelters
Guidance for workers at shelters on keeping people healthy and safe

Determining Shelter Layout
Details on effectively establishing a physical organization of a shelter site in order to deliver services to standards

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations